

Linux system, and those who need the non-free firmware (which is most people) can just enable the non-free repo, and install the firmware. Debian has also switched to a new dependency-based init system (Ubuntu uses an event-based init system), which enables faster boots, with a more structured service start-up pattern.

The artwork team has also done wonders with this release. The new scheme, called SpaceFun (see Figure 1), is based on a cartoonish representation of a rocket leaving Earth and heading towards Saturn. This comprehensive user experience even includes a Plymouth theme. Yes, Debian now supports KMS and Plymouth too, but the latter isn't installed by default.

On the Mozilla front, all is definitely not well, however. Apparently, Mozilla didn't allow Debian to muck around with their branding and logos for newer versions of Firefox. Thus, Debian actually has to make do with Firefox 3.5 and Thunderbird 3.0. Not an issue for me, since I use neither—I use Google Chrome, and yes, Chromium is now an official Debian package. And on that note, Debian now includes Ubuntu's Software Center (version 2, which is in 10.04 Lucid Lynx LTS, and not version 3, which is in 10.10 Maverick Meerkat), which makes software installation that much easier (see Figure 2).

Finally, Debian 6 marks the first-ever release of Debian with EGLibC instead of GLibC. There's a genuine reason for this replacement—apparently, GLibC's developer is not too friendly (to put it mildly), and there have been lots of developmental issues with it. EGLibC isn't a fork of GLibC, it's more like an unofficial branch with a lot of patches. It is binary-compatible with GLibC, and in any case, Ubuntu's been using it since Jaunty.

Well, that's about all I'm willing to give you as an introduction. It's time to get our hands dirty and actually try out Debian 6, to see if it's worth its salt.

Installing Debian 6

Because of Debian's new 'feature' of excluding non-free firmware from the installation media, installation gets interesting. You have a couple of options:

- If your machine does not include any hardware that demands non-free firmware, go ahead and download one of the many DVD, CD, Blu-Ray or USB images of the Debian-Installer Disk Set, and give it a spin.
- If your machine requires a piece of non-free firmware, you have two options. You can use an official CD and place a firmware tarball on a USB drive, which you can use as an 'F6 Disk' (somewhat like when you're installing Windows XP) to supply the firmware to the installer. Alternatively, you can download a specifically crafted NetInstall CD, which includes non-free firmware.

I decided to give it a spin in a VMWare virtual machine, and so downloaded a 47 MB BizCard CD image,

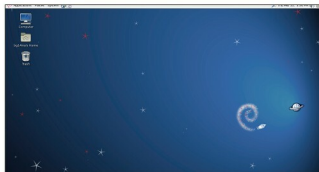


Figure 1: Default desktop



Figure 2: Software Center in Debian



Figure 3: The Debian installer

which would fetch all the packages dynamically off the Internet (in contrast to NetInstall, which includes the base system packages on the CD). To obtain installer images, use the following links:

- Debian CD images: <http://www.debian.org/CD>
- Debian firmware tarball: <http://cdimage.debian.org/cdimage/unofficial/non-free/firmware/squeeze/current>
- Debian NetInstall CD image with firmware: <http://cdimage.debian.org/cdimage/unofficial/non-free/cd-including-firmware/6.0/>

If you do use the official CDs with the firmware tarball, use a USB drive with a single partition either formatted with FAT32 or ext3, and place the firmware tarball in the root of the drive. Keep it attached while installing, and Debian-Installer (see Figure 3) will automatically detect the tarball and use it.

Back to my story. I fired up the VM, booting from the BizCard CD. Once at the boot menu, I opted for the *Graphical Install*. Remarkably, I was staring at the first X-based screen no more than 3 seconds later.